



UPSC CSE 2026

ANTHROPOLOGY OPTIONAL FOUNDATION

INDIAN SOCIETY



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7+ Years Experience

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INDIAN SOCIETY

Paper 2- Chapter 5.1

Handout - 7

Syllabus covered in this Handout:

5.1- Indian Village:

- Significance of village study in India;
- Traditional and changing patterns of settlement and inter-caste relations,
- Little republics, Rural Cosmopolitanism,
- Agrarian relations in Indian villages,
- Impact of Globalization on Indian Village,
- Indian Village as a Social System,
- Traditional Culture.

VILLAGE STUDY IN INDIAN AND ITS SIGNIFICANCE

Village studies in anthropology in India involve in-depth investigations into the **social, cultural, economic, and political dynamics** of rural communities. Anthropologists conduct fieldwork to understand the **intricate relationships, traditional practices, and socio-economic structures** within villages, providing valuable insights into the diverse and complex fabric of Indian rural life. These studies contribute to a deeper comprehension of the dynamics shaping village societies, offering a **holistic perspective** on the intersections of **tradition** and **modernity** in the Indian context.

1. Diversity of Indian Villages

Indian villages exhibit a significant degree of **internal and external diversity**, characterized by complex social relationships and institutional structures.

(Different Views on Indian Villages)

- **Mahatma Gandhi:** Said “*India lives in its villages.*” For him, the village was autonomous, self-sufficient, and moral, representing authentic and sustainable life.
- **Jawaharlal Nehru:** Did not romanticize villages. He saw them as sites of backwardness, poverty, and stagnation, and believed India’s future lay in industrialization and modernization.

- **B.R. Ambedkar**: Was highly critical. He called villages “a sink of localism, a den of ignorance, and a place of oppression”, pointing to caste discrimination and marginalization of Dalits.)

2. Chicago School's Impact (1950s-60s)

Influential anthropologists from the **Chicago School**, including **Robert Redfield**, **Milton Singer**, and **McKim Marriot**, played a pivotal role in shaping the **theoretical** and **methodological foundations** of Indian village studies during the 1950s and 60s.

3. Concept of Village Study

Village studies involve selecting a **specific village** as a **unit of investigation**, providing **ethnographic insights** through **participant observation**. **Redfield** introduced the **analytical concept of village India**.

4. Historical Background

In the 1930s, **William Wiser** published works like *Hindu Jajmani System* and *Behind the Mud Walls*, contributing to the **historical background** of village studies.

5. D.N. Majumdar's Contribution

D.N. Majumdar's *Caste and Communication in an Indian Village* illustrated the **impact of new means of transport and communication on caste mobility**.

6. S.C. Dube's Classic Village Study

S.C. Dube's *Indian Village* is considered a **classic** in village studies, providing valuable insights into the **social dynamics** of rural India.

7. Oscar Lewis's Work on Rural Cosmopolitanism

Oscar Lewis explored **Rural Cosmopolitanism**, adding another dimension to the understanding of **village life** in India.

Significance of Village Study:

1. Theoretical Level

- **Dominant Caste (M.N. Srinivas)**: Explores the **influential caste** within a village.
- **Sanskritization and Westernization (M.N. Srinivas)**: Ideas on **cultural changes** driven by **emulation of higher castes** and **Western influences**.
- **Little Republics vs. Rural Cosmopolitanism**: Contrasts between **Charles Metcalfe's** “Little Republics” and **Oscar Lewis's** “Rural Cosmopolitanism” highlight diverse **village social structures**.

- **Little and Great Traditions (Robert Redfield)**: Distinguishes between **local village traditions** and **broader cultural influences**.
- **Universalization and Parochialization (McKim Marriott)**: Explores the **tension** between **universal** and **local values**.
- **Sacred Complex (L.P. Vidyarthi)**: Concept of **interconnectedness of religious beliefs** in the village.
- **Nature-Man-Spirit Complex (L.P. Vidyarthi)**: Exploration of the **relationship between nature, humanity, and spirituality**, contributing to theoretical richness.

Village studies, therefore, not only provide a **nuanced understanding** of the **social dynamics** at the **village level** but also contribute to the development of **theoretical frameworks** that shape the broader field of **anthropology in India**.

2. APPLIED LEVEL: (This will be discussed in detail in the subsequent topics.)

Village studies also helped in **policy and planning**.

Example 1: Community Development Programs (1950s onwards)

- India launched community development blocks for rural progress.
- Village studies showed a problem: if ₹1 crore was given for development, it often went first to **dominant caste hamlets**.
- Roads, wells, and electricity poles appeared in upper caste areas, while Dalit hamlets remained neglected.
- This highlighted how **inequality can grow despite development schemes**.

Example 2: Tribal Development Programs

- The **Tribal Sub-Plan (1974)** aimed to funnel funds to tribal communities.
- Anthropologists showed how non-tribal intermediaries often captured benefits.
- For example, in Madhya Pradesh and Odisha, contractors or moneylenders took over schemes meant for tribal welfare.

Example 3: Barriers to Social Change

- **George Foster's concept of "Traditional Culture"**: societies glorify their past and resist change.
- Example: Public toilets under government schemes often failed in villages because **caste prejudices** made people refuse to share bathrooms.

- Similarly, some resisted co-education in schools because of traditional gender norms.

Village studies in India bridged **theory** and **practice**, enriching **anthropology** with concepts like **dominant caste** and **Sanskritization**, while also guiding **planners** in **rural development**. They remain vital in understanding the **pulse of rural India**, where **tradition** and **modernity** continue to intersect.

INDIAN VILLAGES - CHANGE IN PATTERNS OF SETTLEMENTS

Rural Settlement Patterns in India:

India's rural settlements are diverse because they are shaped by geography, culture, security, and economic needs. The patterns vary from one region to another.

Factors Responsible for Different Types of Rural Settlements:

1. Physical Features:

- **Altitude, climate, and water availability** directly influence where people live.
- In the **Himalayas**, villages are clustered in valleys to use fertile land and avoid harsh weather.
- In **arid regions like Rajasthan**, settlements are scattered around oases and wells due to scarce water.

2. Cultural and Ethnic Factors

- **Caste, religion, and social structure** shape settlement patterns.
- Some communities prefer to live close together based on cultural ties.
- In **South India**, villages often develop around temples, creating a sense of identity and community.

3. Security Considerations

- In areas prone to **raids, thefts, or invasions**, people lived in **clustered and fortified villages** for protection.
- Examples can be seen in **fortified villages and forts** across different regions of India.

4. Economic Factors

- Proximity to **agricultural land, trade routes, or coasts** also influences settlements.
- **Fertile plains** → agrarian settlements.
- **Coastal areas** → fishing villages.
- **Market routes** → settlements near trade centres.

Thus, Rural settlement patterns in India reflect an interplay of **geography, culture, security, and economy**. Together, these factors have shaped the **unique rural landscape** of India over centuries.

Different Types of Rural Settlements:

Rural settlements in India can broadly be put into four types:

1. Clustered, agglomerated Or nucleated
2. Semi-clustered Or fragmented
3. Hamleted
4. Dispersed or isolated.

1. Clustered Settlements:

The clustered rural settlement is a **compact or closely built area** of houses. In this type of village the general living area is distinct and separated from the surrounding farms, barns and pastures. Such settlements are generally found in **fertile alluvial plains and in the northeastern states**. Sometimes, people live in compact villages for **security or defense reasons**.

Regions: Bundelkhand region of central India and in Nagaland.

In Rajasthan - scarcity of water has necessitated compact settlement for maximum utilization of available water resources.

2. Semi-Clustered Settlements:

Semi-clustered or fragmented settlements *may result from the tendency of clustering in a restricted area of dispersed settlement*. More often such a pattern may also result from **segregation or fragmentation of a large compact village**. In this case, one or more sections of the village society choose or are forced to live *a little away from the main cluster or village*.

In such cases, generally, the land-owning and dominant community occupies the central part of the main village, whereas people of **lower strata** of society and menial workers settle on the **outer flanks** of the village.

Regions: Gujarat plain and some parts of Rajasthan.

3. Hamleted Settlements:

Sometimes settlement is **fragmented into several units** physically separated from each other bearing a common name. These units are locally called **panna, para, palli, nagla, dhani**, etc. In various parts of the country, this segmentation of a large village is often motivated by social and ethnic factors.

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Regions: Such villages are more frequently found in the middle and lower Ganga plain, Chhattisgarh and lower valleys of the Himalayas.

4. Dispersed Settlements:

Dispersed or isolated settlement patterns in India appear in the *form of isolated huts or hamlets of few huts in remote jungles, or on small hills with farms or pasture on the slopes*. **Extreme dispersion of settlement** is often caused by the extremely **fragmented** nature of the terrain and land resource base of habitable areas.

Regions: Many areas of Meghalaya, Uttarakhand, Himachal Pradesh and Kerala have this type of settlement.

In conclusion, the varied rural settlement patterns in India, influenced by physical features, cultural and ethnic factors, and security considerations, encompass clustered settlements in fertile plains, semi-clustered formations with social stratification, hamleted configurations motivated by social and ethnic factors, and dispersed settlements dictated by the challenging terrain and land resource distribution, reflecting the diverse geographical and sociocultural landscape of the country.

Changes in Settlement Patterns:

Anthropologically, changes in rural settlement patterns in India can be analyzed through the lens of various socio-cultural factors. Here are some reasons for the change, with a focus on caste, class, jajmani system, social mobility, and modernization:

Caste Dynamics:

- Traditional rural settlement patterns in India were often influenced by the caste system, with specific areas designated for different castes. Over time, changes in social attitudes and government policies aimed at reducing caste-based discrimination have contributed to a more mixed settlement pattern.
- Increased social awareness and movements advocating for the rights of marginalized castes have challenged traditional spatial hierarchies, leading to a shift in settlement patterns.

Class and Economic Changes:

- Economic factors play a crucial role in shaping rural settlement patterns.
- Changes in agricultural practices, land reforms, and economic opportunities have led to shifts in settlement locations.

- As economic activities diversify beyond agriculture, new opportunities emerged in certain regions, attracting people and altering settlement patterns based on class and economic considerations.

Jajmani System and Occupational Changes:

- The jajmani system, a traditional economic arrangement where different castes provide specific services to others, has historically influenced settlement patterns. Changes in occupational structures, such as the decline of traditional occupations and the rise of new industries, impacted settlement locations.
- Modernization and globalization led to the erosion of the jajmani system as people seek alternative economic opportunities, contributing to changes in settlement patterns.

Social Mobility:

- Changes in social mobility, facilitated by education and access to resources, can influence where people choose to settle. Increased mobility led to the migration of individuals or families to urban or peri-urban areas for better educational and employment prospects.
- Social mobility challenged traditional settlement patterns by allowing individuals to move outside their designated caste-specific areas, contributing to a more diverse and mixed settlement landscape.

Modernization and Infrastructure Development:

- The process of modernization, marked by technological advancements and infrastructure development, can significantly impact rural settlement patterns. Improved transportation, communication, and access to amenities encouraged people to move away from isolated or less-developed areas.
- Modernization also led to the growth of market towns and urban centers, attracting populations away from traditional agrarian settlements.

Government Policies and Land Reforms:

- Government policies, particularly those related to land reforms and rural development, influenced settlement patterns. Redistribution of land, infrastructure projects, and incentivizing certain types of economic activities led to shifts in population distribution.
- Land reforms aimed at reducing landlessness and promoting equitable land distribution have altered the spatial arrangement of rural settlements.

In conclusion, the anthropological analysis of changes in rural settlement patterns in India involves considering the interplay of **caste dynamics, class structures, the jajmani system, social mobility, and the impact of modernization**. These factors collectively contribute to the dynamic and evolving nature of rural settlements in the country.

LITTLE REPUBLIC AND RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM

ARE INDIAN VILLAGES LITTLE REPUBLICS?

Earlier Perception about Indian Villages:

- Scholars like Henry Maine, Charles Metcalfe, Baden Powell described Indian villages as **self-sufficient and autonomous**.
- They believed villages managed their own affairs without depending on others, like “**Little Republics**.”
- Metcalfe famously said that Indian villages were like **tiny republics, standing firm even when kingdoms rose and fell** around them.
- Maine and Powell also admired this **local autonomy**, considering villages as miniature states capable of independent functioning.

Metcalfe's Idea of Little Republics:

1. Self-Sufficiency and Autonomy

- Villages were seen as **self-reliant units**, with their own **social, economic, and political structures**.
- They managed agriculture, cottage industries, and local needs without heavy dependence on external authorities.

2. Social and Political Independence

- Villages had their own **local governance systems**, such as the **Panchayat**, which resolved disputes and managed affairs.
- This gave them a sense of **self-governance** and reduced dependence on central authority.

3. Role in Social Cohesion

- By maintaining autonomy, villages prevented the **concentration of power** in central authorities.

- They also fostered **community solidarity** and **balanced societal structure**.

Examples

- **Panchayat System:** Village councils acted as local self-government, handling judicial and administrative matters.
- **Traditional Economy:** Agriculture and **cottage industries** made villages relatively independent. Goods and services were often exchanged within the community.

Limitations of the Concept

- Villages were **not completely isolated**.
- They engaged in **trade, communication, and cultural exchange** with nearby villages and towns.
- This shows that while there was autonomy, there was also **interconnectedness**.

Significance

- The idea of “**little republics**” is important for both **anthropology** and **political science**.
- It highlights how **local autonomy** and **self-governance** can ensure **social harmony** and prevent **excessive centralization of power**.
- At the same time, critiques by **Nehru and Ambedkar** remind us that villages were not just sites of autonomy, but also of **inequality, poverty, and caste oppression**.

ARE VILLAGES AUTONOMOUS?

Due to the fact that each village has its own power structure and a few powerful individuals, having control over the village. The **agrarian structure, the Jajmani system**, where people's needs are met through the **exchange of goods and services** and no intervention of the other villages in the working of one village may substantiate that Indian villages are “**little republics**”.

However that is not the case if we look at the socio-cultural institutions like marriage, it is very obvious that a family in a village has ties with the other village. Even the kinship is spread in many villages. The villages depend on the other villages for religious activities like pilgrimages and festivals. These aspects act as the bridge between the forming inter-village ties. This concept is called “**Rural Cosmopolitanism**”.

Oscar Lewis came up with the concept of RURAL **COSMOPOLITANISM**, with his study of **Rani Khera** near New Delhi. With this concept he went **against the “Little Republic”** concept proposed by **Charles Metcalfe**. Oscar Lewis says that villages are not **self-sufficient** and

independent but they always maintain ties with other villages for their social, cultural, economic, religious and political activities.

Oscar Lewis submitted his paper in seminar on Indian villages at the university of Chicago and explained his findings:

- He says that the villages in **Mexico** are “**inward looking**” . They do not have socio- cultural ties with other villages. They follow village **endogamy** and the intervillage network is only for trade purposes.
- On the other hand, the villages in **India** form a **complex network**. These could be socio- cultural ties - marriage, economic ties - trade, religious ties - pilgrimage, political ties. He calls this phenomenon “**RURAL COSMOPOLITANISM**” .
- **Examples:** In the context of India, several examples illustrate the idea of rural cosmopolitanism:
 - **Jallikattu in Tamil Nadu:**
 - Jallikattu is a traditional bull-taming sport that takes place in the villages of Tamil Nadu during the Pongal festival.
 - It involves participants from multiple villages coming together to participate and spectate.
 - The event fosters social bonds and interactions among individuals from different villages, showcasing the interconnectedness of rural communities.
 - **Rath Yatras (Chariot Processions):**
 - Rath Yatras, such as the famous Jagannath Rath Yatra in Puri, Odisha, involve the procession of deities on elaborately decorated chariots.
 - Pilgrims and participants from various villages participate in these processions, creating a sense of shared religious and cultural identity across different rural communities.
 - **Village Fairs and Melas:**
 - Many villages in India host annual fairs and melas that attract participants and visitors from neighboring villages.
 - These events serve as platforms for cultural exchange, economic activities (trade and commerce), and social interactions, reinforcing the idea of rural cosmopolitanism.

Thus, Indian villages are not isolated “**little republics**” but **dynamic, interconnected communities** shaped by **social, economic, and cultural change**. Anthropological studies show that villagers are **active agents**, adapting and reshaping their societies, making it necessary to view villages as **complex** and **evolving social formations**.

AGRARIAN RELATIONS IN INDIAN VILLAGES

The **agrarian social structure in India** refers to the organization of rural life around **agriculture**, marked by **caste hierarchies, land ownership and tenancy patterns**, and **gender inequalities**. Land is often concentrated in the hands of a few, while most farmers are tenants or laborers. This structure shapes the **social relations, power, and livelihoods** of rural communities.

_____ posits that the agrarian social structure is contingent upon two key components:

- **technological arrangements**, which encompass the machinery and technology employed for agricultural purposes, and
- **social arrangements**, which involve the power structure, land ownership, and control.

Furthermore, as technological advancements increase, the reliance on social arrangements tends to decrease, and conversely, heightened dependence on social arrangements often coincides with a lesser reliance on advanced technology in agrarian contexts.

He also says that in some Asian societies economic and social institutions are interconnected.

Peasant society:

A peasant society, as initially conceptualized by A.L. Kroeber, is characterized by agricultural predominance, with Kroeber defining it as a "part society" signifying its reliance on a larger society across technological, economic, political, administrative, religious, and moral spheres; within these peasant societies, social structures are intricately woven into the fabric of caste and class relationships.

Daniel Thorner classifies this society into 3 parts

1. Proprietors/ Landowners/ Malik.
2. Working peasants/ Kisan/ Tenants.
3. Laborer/ Mazdoor.

- **Maliks (Proprietors or Landowners)**
 - Mostly **rich upper-caste groups** owning large tracts of land.
 - They held dominant power in rural society.
 - **Examples:** Zamindars and Jagirdars before independence.
- **Kisans (Working Peasants or Tenants)**
 - Belongs largely to **middle castes** in the hierarchy.
 - Some were **small landowners**, while others worked as **tenants** leasing land from Maliks.
 - Considered the “**backbone of cultivation**” in Indian agriculture.
- **Mazdoors (Agricultural Laborers)**
 - Mostly **landless workers** from **lower castes**.
 - Dependent on **wages, sharecropping, or casual labor** on Malik and Kisan lands.
 - Occupied the lowest rung of the agrarian social structure.

This social structure which was highly dominant has seen significant decline post independence due to **social mobility** and **depeasantization** which has given rise to other new powerful classes and castes.

D.N. Dhanangre (1983) says that although Thorner's categories and subcategories are nearer the realities of the Indian agrarian social structure, there is still a need to regroup these categories into such a **broader** and more **comprehensive model** and redesignate them into commonly used concepts and criteria in the study of peasant societies. Such a model can be drawn from the works of **Lenin and Mao**, especially those relating to the analysis of agrarian classes in the **Russian** and **Chinese** societies respectively:

- **Landlords** - large landowners, often not cultivating themselves.
- **Rich peasants** - owned enough land to hire laborers.
- **Middle peasants** - small landholders, usually working with their own family labor.
- **Poor peasants** - very small plots, often dependent on others.
- **Landless laborers** - had no land at all, survived on daily wage labor.

He further opines that the social composition of these agrarian classes in terms of specific status groups like **castes, religious or ethnic groups**, etc. is far too **complex** in different regions of India to reduce into any simplistic formulae. However, for a loose and broad classification that may hold ground.

Social Stratification in Agrarian Societies of India:

- For instance, individuals classified as '**landlords and rich landowners**,' which includes non-cultivating urban money lenders/owners, were predominantly affiliated with upper castes such as **Brahmin, Thakur, or Banias in northern India**. In **Andhra Pradesh**, examples include the **Kammas, Reddis, and Raos, in Mysore**, the **Okkaligas and Lingayat**, the **Patidar** in the **Gujarat** region, and the **Kunbi Marathas and Deshmukhs in Maharashtra**.
- The category of '**middle and poor peasantry**,' largely burdened by debt, primarily comprised individuals from traditional castes of cultivators, artisans, and the like.
- '**Landless laborers**,' predominantly associated with untouchable castes or the scheduled castes, constituted a significant portion of this group.

Changes in agrarian social structure in india:

Changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been happening gradually over the years. Some of the key changes include:

- **Land reforms:** India has implemented various land reforms over the years, aimed at redistributing land ownership and reducing the concentration of land in the hands of a few. These reforms have helped to increase the number of small and marginal farmers and reduce the influence of large landowners.
- **Tenancy patterns:** Tenancy laws have been amended to provide better protection to tenants and improve their access to credit and other resources. This has helped to reduce the power imbalance between landlords and tenants.
- **Caste-based hierarchies:** While caste-based hierarchies still exist in many rural areas, social mobility has increased due to improvements in education and economic opportunities. This has helped to reduce the influence of caste in determining social status and economic opportunities.
- **Gender-based inequalities:** Women's participation in agriculture and access to resources has improved over the years, due to various government policies and programs aimed at promoting gender equality in rural areas.

Overall, changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been slow and incremental, but they have helped to address some of the key issues related to land ownership, tenancy patterns, caste-based hierarchies, and gender-based inequalities. There is still a long way to go in terms of

promoting social change and development in rural areas, but these changes are a step in the right direction

Reasons for changes in agrarian social structure in India:

There are several reasons for the changes in agrarian social structure in India. Some of the key reasons include:

- **Government policies:** The Indian government has implemented various policies and programs aimed at promoting land reforms, improving tenancy patterns, and advancing gender equality in rural areas. These policies have had a significant impact on the agrarian social structure in India.
- **Economic factors:** Economic changes, such as the growth of non-agricultural industries and the rise of the service sector, have led to a decline in the importance of agriculture as a source of livelihood. This has led to changes in land ownership patterns and increased the number of small and marginal farmers.
- **Social factors:** Social changes, such as improvements in education and increased mobility, have led to changes in caste-based hierarchies and increased social mobility.
- **Technological advances:** Technological advances, such as improved irrigation systems and farm machinery, have led to changes in agricultural practices and increased productivity. This has led to changes in land ownership patterns and increased the number of small and medium-sized farms.

Overall, the changes in the agrarian social structure in India have been driven by a combination of government policies, economic and social factors, and technological advances. These changes have helped to address some of the key issues related to land ownership, tenancy patterns, caste-based hierarchies, and gender-based inequalities in rural areas.

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IMPACT OF GLOBALIZATION ON INDIAN VILLAGES

Globalization is the **process by which the world is becoming increasingly interconnected as a result of massively increased trade and cultural exchange**. It has accelerated since the 18th century due to advances in transportation and communication technology.

- **Anthony Giddens** describes it as the **gradual integration of economies and societies** across the world.
- In short, globalization refers to the **interconnectedness and interdependence** of nations, cultures, and communities at a global scale.

Indian Villages- Pre Globalization:

Villages are the centers of self-sufficiency, embodiment of collectivism. Indian villages mostly followed the pre-literate and early methods of **Economic practices** which contributed to the well-founded **social relations** between different caste people. Jajmani system is one such example.

Impact of Globalization on Indian Villages:

- **Major Trends in Village Economy:**
 - AR Desai's Perspective :
 - Four major trends include
 - the transformation from subsistence to surplus economy,
 - introduction of modern technology,
 - abolition of intermediaries like Zamindars, and
 - the emergence of associations and institutions linked with urban and national organizations.
- **Transformation of Agrarian Relations:**
 - **Chand and Srivastava's Study (2014 - Jamgod Village, Madhya Pradesh):**
 - Traditional agrarian relations favoring the local dominant caste have been disrupted, leading to a shift towards contract-based employment over traditional payment in kind.
- **Depeasantization and Change in Status Calculations:**
 - **Tilche's Study (Patidars of Sundarana Village, Gujarat):**

- Globalization has enabled Patidars, a traditional agricultural community, to free themselves from agriculture through education, employment, and emigration to urban areas, reshaping their status calculations.
- **Emergence of New Conflicts and Changes in Traditional Practices:**
 - **Simpson's Analysis (2016) of Various Village Studies:**
 - Market economy and education have given rise to conflicts between agricultural and non-agricultural ways of life, leading to the decline of the jajmani system and a reduced appeal for Sanskritisation.
- **Disruption of Joint Families:**
 - *Jnavati Kanve* 's Observation (Weakening of Ties):
 - Globalization has contributed to the disruption of joint families in Indian villages.
- **Decline in Jajmani System:**
 - The **JAJMANI SYSTEM** is one of practices which was greatly hit by globalization and rarely observed today in some rural areas.
 - **William Wiser's Definition:**
 - The Jajmani system, where each caste group provides standardized services to other castes, has declined due to factors such as the **role of the state, technological innovations, and political mobilization.**
- **Impact on Social Customs and Traditions:**
 - The westernization of culture through global media has eroded traditional values and customs, questioning age-old practices.
- **Impact on Agriculture:**
 - Globalization has facilitated mobility and connectivity, leading to rapid migration for employment outside the agricultural sector.
 - Agricultural tools and practices have evolved with mechanization, improved seeds, fertilizers, and pesticides, benefiting big, rich farmers.

In conclusion, the impact of globalization on Indian village societies is multifaceted, encompassing transformations in **agrarian relations, depeasantization, changes in status calculations, the emergence of new conflicts, disruption of traditional practices, and the decline of**

systems like the Jajmani system. The shift towards a surplus economy, introduction of modern technology, and changes in social customs and agriculture reflect the intricate dynamics through which global forces have reshaped and challenged the traditional fabric of village life in India.

INDIAN VILLAGE AS A SOCIAL SYSTEM:

System implies an **orderly arrangement, inter-relationship** of parts in which every part has a fixed place and definite role. These parts do not exist in isolation but are bound by a **constant interaction**. When this understanding of the system is applied to the Social System, we get an insight into the working of the social system.

Social system is the **patterned** series of **interrelationships** existing between **individuals, groups, and institutions** and forming a coherent whole.

According to Talcott Parsons, "Social system consists of a plurality of social actors engaged in more or less stable **interaction** according to **shared cultural norms and meaning**".

He further adds:

- Here the interaction is '**patterned interaction**'.
- It takes under its orbit all the diverse **sub-systems** such as economic, political, religious and others.

Key Features of a Social System:

- **Plurality of Individual Actors:**
 - Implies the necessity of multiple interacting individuals within the system.
 - Eg: The Indian village comprises a diverse population engaged in various social roles, including individuals from different castes, occupations, and age groups, contributing to the plurality of social actors within the village.
- **Aims and Objectives:**
 - Every social system must possess specific aims and objectives, avoiding aimlessness.
 - Eg: Like any social system, an Indian village is not aimless; it pursues specific aims and objectives. These objectives may involve maintaining social harmony, preserving cultural traditions, and ensuring the well-being of its members.
- **Order and Pattern:**
 - Requires an organized structure with order among various functional units.

- Eg: Within the Indian village, there exists an order and pattern among various functional constituents or units. The economic, political, religious, and other subsystems coexist and interact, forming a structured social organization.
- **Functional Unity:**
 - The unity between constituents is established through functional relationships.
 - Eg: The unity within the Indian village is established through functional relationships between its constituents. Economic activities, religious practices, and social interactions contribute to the overall stability and functioning of the village as a social system.
- **Maintenance:**
 - Achieved through socialization and social control, vital for the system's longevity.
 - Eg: The Indian village's endurance as a social system hinges on maintenance, which combines socialization, ensuring the transmission of cultural norms to younger generations and social control. The latter, involving the enforcement of rules, is vital for maintaining order and preventing disruptions that could jeopardize the continuity of the social system.

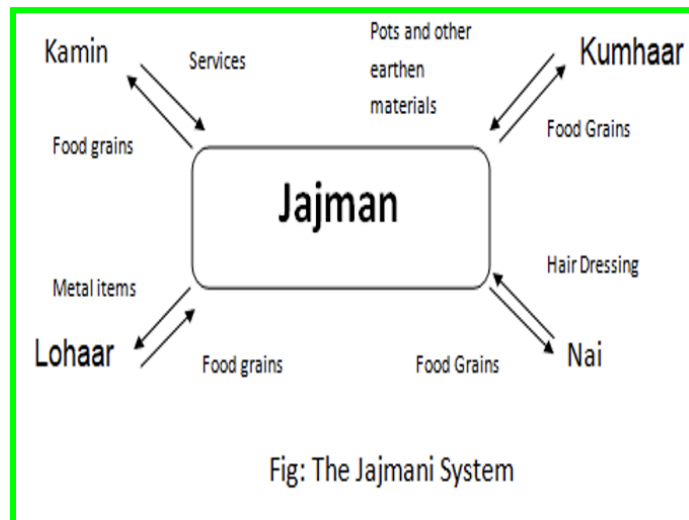
How can we say Indian Village as a Social System?

Now, if we look at the Indian village, we find all the important features of the social system in it.

- There is **constant interaction between the individuals** and there is no anonymity because of the small population and high density of population.

1. Caste and Jajmani System:

- **Plurality of actors:** Different castes (Brahmins, artisans, service castes) form multiple actors in constant interaction.
- **Order and pattern:** Caste hierarchy gives a fixed order, while Jajmani defines who provides what service.
- **Functional unity:** Interdependence in Jajmani (e.g., barber cuts hair, farmer gives grain) keeps the village running like a body with organs.
- This shows that caste-Jajmani is not isolated, it is a **subsystem ensuring economic and ritual order**.



2. Panchayati Raj System:

- **Aims and objectives:** Ensures local governance, justice, and development. Avoids aimlessness by setting common goals.
- **Order and pattern:** Democratic rules, elections, and dispute resolution bring stability in social and political life.
- **Maintenance:** Social control is exercised by panchayats, reducing conflict and enforcing norms.
- Therefore, Panchayat works as the **political subsystem** of the village, aligning with Parsons' idea of maintaining order.

3. Joint Family System:

- **Plurality of actors:** Many generations live together, interacting daily as actors in a shared household.
- **Functional unity:** Family members divide roles-elders guide, adults earn, children learn. Unity arises from shared labor and values.
- **Maintenance:** Socialization of children, discipline of members, and transmission of culture ensure continuity.
- The joint family is the **socialization and control subsystem**, ensuring value transmission.

Summary:

- Caste-Jajmani = **Economic-ritual order**
- Panchayati Raj = **Political order and control**
- Joint Family = **Socialization and cultural maintenance**

- Together, they fulfill all **five features of Parsons' social system**: plurality, aims, order, functional unity, and maintenance.
- Therefore, the Indian village is a **cohesive social system**, and within the larger Indian society, it acts as a **subsystem**.

In summary, the Indian village, with its constant interaction, deep-rooted social structures like the caste system and Jajmani norms, and the role of Panchayati Raj and joint family systems in socialization and control, exhibits all the crucial features of a social system. Therefore, it can be confidently affirmed that the Indian village serves as a cohesive and functioning social system within the broader societal framework.

TRADITIONAL CULTURE:

Definition

- **George Foster**, an American anthropologist, developed the concept of “**Traditional Culture**” from his fieldwork in **Mexico** (Latin America).
- He defined it as the **cultural practices and beliefs transmitted from one generation to the next**, creating continuity and stability in society.

Key Features

1. Stability and Coherence

- Traditions are preserved carefully, often through **oral transmission** (songs, rhymes, rituals).
- People follow the path of their **forefathers**, ensuring continuity.

2. Identity and Continuity

- Provides a **sense of belonging and order** in society.
- Festivals, fairs, and community gatherings reinforce cultural values.

3. Adaptiveness and Change

- While traditions are stable, they may **adapt slowly** to the environment and new challenges.
- However, change is often resisted if it threatens core cultural values.

How it Creates Barriers to Social Change

- Cultural patterns may **resist modernization** or new practices.
- Traditions can become **cultural barriers** that hinder reforms.
- Example:
 - **Gender roles** in rural Africa limit women's education and employment.
 - **Resistance to Western medicine** among indigenous groups due to faith in traditional healing.
 - **Resource use in tribal South America** (hunting, fishing traditions) conflicting with conservation laws.

Indian Examples of Traditional Culture as a Barrier

1. Caste System

- The caste system is one of the oldest cultural practices in India.
- It enforces **rigid social segregation** where interaction, marriage, and even residence are shaped by caste.
- Higher castes traditionally controlled resources and rituals, while lower castes were marginalized.
- This system **limits social mobility** and blocks reforms aimed at equality. For example, Dalits continue to face exclusion in village resources such as wells and temples.

2. Sanitation Practices

- A study by Dean Spears and Michael Genuso (2018) found that Hindus were far less likely than Muslims to use toilets, even at the same income level.
- The traditional belief that **open defecation away from the home is "purer"** than keeping waste inside the house acts as a cultural barrier to modern sanitation.
- This leads to high levels of open defecation in India, contributing to child mortality and poor health outcomes, despite government investments in sanitation (e.g., Swachh Bharat Abhiyan).

3. Caste Segregation in Villages (Karnataka Case)

- Research by Naveen Bharathi, et al (2020) shows that **intra-village segregation in Karnataka is greater than black-white segregation in the American South.**

- Ethnographic research (e.g., Spatz & Leach, 1954) documents how residential space in rural India mirrors **caste hierarchy**.
- **Village example: Amminabhavi** (near Dharwad, Karnataka) is a classic case:
 - i. **Dalits (formerly “untouchables,” labelled Harijans in early studies)** are pushed to the **periphery** of the village.
 - ii. **Dominant landholding castes** occupy the **center of the village**.
 - iii. Other worker castes such as **Talwars, Shepherds, and Washermen** are also relegated to the margins.
 - iv. The **village headman** and his kin control the **best land parcels**, often living in a large “manor house.”
- Ambedkar famously called Indian villages a **“sink of localism and a den of narrow-mindedness,”** pointing to such entrenched practices.

4. Child Marriage

- Rooted in cultural values of **family honor and purity**, girls are often married off at a young age.
- This traditional practice **restricts education and economic opportunities** for women.
- It also increases risks of **early pregnancies, poor health, and domestic violence**.
- Despite legal prohibition, it persists in many rural areas because it is deeply tied to traditional notions of social order.

5. Female Infanticide

- Traditional preference for **male children** has led to practices such as female infanticide and later, sex-selective abortions.
- This reflects cultural beliefs that sons ensure lineage, provide economic support, and perform last rites, while daughters are seen as a financial burden (due to dowry).
- The result is a **distorted sex ratio**, which itself becomes a barrier to gender equality and social reform.

Criticism

- Too **simplistic**: assumes cultures are static.
- Overlooks that traditions are **dynamic, evolving, and negotiable**.

- Sometimes used to justify **cultural purity** and **exclude minorities**.

In conclusion, Foster's concept of **Traditional Culture** highlights the dual role of traditions in society. On one hand, they preserve identity, continuity, and stability, while on the other, they can act as barriers to social change, as seen in practices like **caste segregation** or **sanitation beliefs**. For meaningful development, it is essential that reforms engage with cultural values rather than work against them. In this sense, culture can be seen as both a **shield** that protects communities and a **wall** that obstructs progressive change unless addressed with sensitivity.



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